

■
 Explainer

What to avoid when pregnant

How to keep your growing baby safe.





Every parent wants to give their child the best start in life, and it’s something you can work on before your child is even born. As your body changes, some of your habits may need to change too. Here are some tips for things to avoid when pregnant to help keep your growing baby safe.

> [Read: Pregnancy milestones by trimester](#)

Foods to avoid during pregnancy

Practicing safe nutrition is essential to a healthy pregnancy for both you and your baby. To prevent harmful infections, we recommend the following:

Do not consume

- Raw, unpasteurized milk
- Soft cheeses made from unpasteurized milk
- Food past its expiration date
- Raw meat
- Undercooked meat products such as sausages and cold cuts
- Uncooked fish and seafood
- Smoked fish
- Uncooked sprouted seeds, grains and beans
- Raw eggs

Food safety tips

- Wash hands with soap before eating
- Wash all eating utensils thoroughly after use
- Cook meat thoroughly
- Wash uncooked vegetables, salad leaves and fruit carefully before eating
- Store food at the appropriate temperature
- Consume food immediately after cooking

> [Read: What to eat when pregnant](#)

Alcohol and pregnancy

You’ve likely heard that consuming alcohol during pregnancy is dangerous, and here’s why: Children heavily exposed to alcohol while in the womb have a higher risk for impaired growth and may develop neural disorders. These result in serious learning and behavioural problems. Even children exposed to smaller quantities of alcohol may develop similar but milder symptoms. During your pregnancy, it is in your baby’s best interest to refrain from consuming any alcoholic beverages.

Smoking and pregnancy

It can be difficult to stop smoking, but protecting your baby from tobacco smoke is so important to giving your little one a healthy start in life. Smoking cigarettes can restrict oxygen supply to your baby and increases the risk of low birth weight. Children whose parents smoke are also more likely to develop asthma and other serious illnesses. For help with quitting tobacco, consult your healthcare provider. Resources from the World Health Organization are also available online.

Caffeine and pregnancy

As hard as it may be to give up your second cup of tea or coffee, it’s recommended to keep an eye on your caffeine intake for the next nine months. Large quantities of caffeine restrict fetal development, and it is recommended that pregnant women not exceed 200 mg per day. The amount of caffeine in foods and drinks varies, so be sure to read nutrition labels closely.

Self-care during pregnancy

Your pregnant body is growing a human being – it’s nothing short of a miracle. During this time, it is especially important to take care of yourself.

- Eat a variety of healthy foods such as meat, nuts, seeds, cereals, beans, fruits and vegetables to help your body receive the nutrients it needs.
- Take prenatal vitamins as recommended by your healthcare provider.
- Avoid lifting heavy objects.
- Avoid exposure to second-hand smoke.
- Look after your mental health by sharing your feelings with a trusted friend or family member, doing calming breathing exercises if you feel overwhelmed and engaging in moderate physical activity.
- Move your body, but do not exhaust yourself. You should be able to hold a conversation when you exercise during your pregnancy.

If you are ever unsure of whether any foods or behaviours are safe during pregnancy, always consult with your healthcare provider.

